



THE BANDS OF ASHLEY HIGH SCHOOL

Wilmington, North Carolina · ashleybands.com

RECOGNIZED STATEWIDE PROGRAM OF DISTINCTION

Inaugural class · 2025-2026
North Carolina Bandmasters Association



COMPLETE MEDIA KIT | CARNEGIE HALL 2027

ASHLEY BANDS: *Everything You Need to Know.*

Prepared for media, civic, campaign, and sponsorship partners. This kit contains the full story, the program record, trip and campaign details, business giving, community impact, director and program biographies, key contacts, and a press release ready for publication.

01	THE STORY	The comeback from COVID, the seven-year rebuild, Mr. Parker's Carnegie connection
02	THE RECORD	NCBA Program of Distinction, MPA Superiors, director recognition, program record
03	THE OPPORTUNITY	Trip details, the March 2027 performance, about 100 students
04	THE CAMPAIGN	\$250,000 goal, what it funds, how to give
05	SPONSORSHIP	Business gifts, community giving, how we say thank you
06	COMMUNITY IMPACT	Why this matters locally and what students bring home
07	BIOS AND CONTACTS	Director bio, program bio, media contacts
08	PRESS RELEASE	AP-style release, ready for publication



September 2026 | Ashley Bands Carnegie Hall 2027 | For inquiries: robert.parker@nhcs.net



01 | THE STORY

SEVEN YEARS TO GET HERE. *One night at Carnegie Hall.*

About 100 Eugene Ashley High School musicians will perform at Carnegie Hall's Stern Auditorium / Perelman Stage on March 25, 2027. Both the Concert Band and the Wind Ensemble submitted recordings and were selected through the festival's application process. Separately, the same program was named to the inaugural class of the NCBA Program of Distinction. Two separate achievements. One program.

THE COMEBACK

The Ashley band program did not arrive at Carnegie Hall on a straight line. Robert A. Parker became Director of Bands in 2006 and spent the next years building a program that could sustain excellence across student generations. Then COVID nearly ended it. The program fell to about 52 students, rehearsing outside in masks. COVID did not just cancel performances. It cut the chain that passes musical habits from older students to younger ones.

During the shutdown, Mr. Parker said rebuilding would take seven years. Class after class learned the program, stayed, and taught the next group, reestablishing ensemble listening, rehearsal standards, and the expectation of what this program produces. Most of the students who did that work graduated before the invitation came. The 2026-2027 season is the seventh since the shutdown.

THE AUDIBLE RESULT

In 2026, both concert ensembles earned Superior ratings at Music Performance Adjudication: the Concert Band at Grade IV repertoire, the Wind Ensemble at Grade VI. Two of the Wind Ensemble pieces were from the 2020 program that COVID canceled. This fall's enrollment is the second highest of Mr. Parker's twenty years at Ashley. Ashley also joined the inaugural class of NCBA Programs of Distinction. Separately, both ensembles submitted recordings and were selected to perform at Carnegie Hall.

A PERSONAL CONNECTION

As a freshman at Mount Tabor High School, Robert Parker performed at Carnegie Hall with his own band. The 2027 trip brings him back, this time on the podium, with his students. That detail is part of the published Ashley Bands story and is available for media use.

WHY THIS MOMENT MATTERS

The performance gives about 100 students a concrete artistic goal and the chance to carry Wilmington and New Hanover County onto a national stage. The campaign asks the community to help make participation possible across family financial circumstances. The lasting result is not the performance itself. It is what these students bring back: musical confidence, stronger ensemble habits, and a raised sense of what is possible for every student who comes after them through this program.



A DOCUMENTED RECORD OF *sustained excellence.*

Ashley's record is public. Each item below is documented through the relevant organization and available for media use. The Carnegie Hall selection was its own application and is described in section 03.

2025-2026 NCBA PROGRAM OF DISTINCTION

The North Carolina Bandmasters Association named Ashley to the inaugural class of its Program of Distinction. Ashley applied in the recognition's first year. NCBA's criteria are musical excellence, performance, community outreach, and advocacy. The New Hanover County Board of Education recognized the program on September 1, 2026.

2026 CONCERT MPA: BOTH ENSEMBLES SUPERIOR

Concert Band: Superior rating at Grade IV repertoire difficulty. Wind Ensemble: Superior rating at Grade VI repertoire difficulty. Both ensembles were adjudicated at the same Music Performance Adjudication event. (Grade describes repertoire difficulty, not a student's school grade.)

2016 NCMEA CONFERENCE PERFORMANCE

The Ashley Wind Ensemble was selected to perform at the North Carolina Music Educators Association Professional Development Conference in Winston-Salem.

2026 NCBA EASTERN DISTRICT AWARD OF EXCELLENCE

Robert A. Parker received the NCBA Eastern District Award of Excellence in February 2026 and will be recognized at the NCMEA conference during the NCBA Board meeting in November 2026.

2026 SPRING CONCERT: THE LORD OF THE RINGS

The Wind Ensemble performed all five movements of Johan de Meij's Symphony No. 1, "The Lord of the Rings," one of the most ambitious works in the concert band repertoire.

SUPPORTING PUBLIC RECORD

The full story, with linked programs and results: ashleybands.com/our-story



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03 | THE OPPORTUNITY

NEW YORK CITY. PERELMAN STAGE. *March 25, 2027.*

The Bands of Ashley High School, the Concert Band and the Wind Ensemble, will perform at Carnegie Hall's Stern Auditorium / Perelman Stage as part of the National Band and Orchestra Festival. About 100 student musicians. Four days in New York City. Wilmington on a national stage.

TRIP AT A GLANCE

PERFORMANCE DATE	March 25, 2027
TRAVEL DATES	March 23-26, 2027
VENUE	Stern Auditorium / Perelman Stage, Carnegie Hall, New York City
ENSEMBLES	Concert Band and Wind Ensemble, both selected
STUDENTS	About 100 student musicians (planning figure)
SCHOOL	Eugene Ashley High School, Wilmington, NC
DISTRICT	New Hanover County Schools
TOUR OPERATOR	WorldStrides; group deposit received September 2026

THE EXPERIENCE

The four-day trip includes the Carnegie Hall performance and educational experiences in New York City. Performance repertoire and the final traveler roster are still being set as the campaign progresses.

HOW THE SELECTION WORKS

Ashley's Concert Band and Wind Ensemble applied to the National Band and Orchestra Festival at Carnegie Hall with submitted recordings and went through its selection process. Both bands were selected.

The NCBA Program of Distinction is a separate recognition, earned through a separate NCBA application. It is part of the program's record, not the reason for the Carnegie Hall selection.





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04 | THE CAMPAIGN

\$250,000. *Help every student get there.*

A performance selection does not pay for transportation, lodging, meals, or festival participation. The outside-support campaign goal is \$250,000, a working estimate. The campaign exists so that no student has to miss this because of money. Every gift lowers the trip cost for every student who goes.

WHAT THE CAMPAIGN FUNDS

- + Group transportation (motorcoach) and equipment movement
- + Hotel lodging in New York City (March 23-26)
- + Festival participation fees
- + Educational travel activities and meals
- + Approved student travel expenses

Successful outside funding also protects the ordinary program resources (instruments, repairs, music, and daily instruction) that keep Ashley Bands strong for students who are not on this trip.

HOW GIFTS ARE USED

Every gift goes to the group trip and lowers the trip cost for every student who goes. Gifts do not create an individual student balance. If the trip changes, the giving page explains how gifts are used.

CAMPAIGN GOALS

FIRST GOAL	\$25,000
NEXT GOAL	\$85,000
FULL GOAL	\$250,000 (estimate)

Live progress is shown on ashleybands.com.

HOW TO GIVE



Online: ashleybands.com/support-carnegie

Checks payable to: Ashley High School Band Boosters, with "Carnegie" on the memo line

Larger gifts and employer matches: Mr. Parker, robert.parker@nhcs.net

Gifts are received by Ashley High School Band Boosters, a registered 501(c)(3) nonprofit organization. Contributions are tax-deductible to the extent allowed by law. EIN: 20-5605218.



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05 | SPONSORSHIP

PUT YOUR BUSINESS *on that stage.*

Business gifts are received by the Ashley High School Band Boosters. Every gift goes to the group trip (travel, lodging, and performance costs) and lowers the cost for every student who goes.

BUSINESS GIFTS

\$500

\$1,000

\$2,500

\$5,000

\$10,000+

ANY AMOUNT

\$2,500 is about one student's estimated trip cost. It is not a final price or a gift to a named student. Business link: ashleybands.com/support-carnegie?kind=business

COMMUNITY AND INDIVIDUAL GIVING

Suggested amounts: \$25 · \$50 · \$100 · \$250 · \$500 · or any amount. An "other amount" option is available online.

At the 100-student planning figure, a \$5,000 shared gift represents \$50 per student toward the group cost. This illustrates shared impact, not an individual student price or a guaranteed allocation.

OTHER WAYS TO HELP

- + Introduce a prospective major donor or civic partner
- + Ask about an employer matching gift. It could double your gift.
- + Host a community fundraiser in coordination with the campaign team
- + Discuss a specific in-kind need before committing goods or services

HOW WE SAY THANK YOU

Every sponsoring business and supporter is thanked by name on ashleybands.com, with a logo if the business sends a print-ready file. Anonymity is respected on request. There are no tiers, tickets, advertising, or merchandise attached to a gift.





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06 | COMMUNITY IMPACT

WHAT WILMINGTON INVESTS IN. *What comes home.*

Carnegie Hall is a visible milestone. But the return on this investment is not a plaque on a wall. It is what about 100 students carry back to Ashley High School and to every student who follows them through this program.

NEW HANOVER COUNTY ON A NATIONAL STAGE

The Bands of Ashley High School represent southern New Hanover County on one of the most recognized stages in the world. For Wilmington, this is not just a school trip. It is a public statement about what this community's public schools produce.

WHAT STUDENTS BRING HOME

Students who perform at Carnegie Hall come back with something that does not wash off: the musical confidence, ensemble discipline, and expanded sense of what is possible that only comes from preparing for and delivering a performance at that level. Those habits and expectations flow directly to younger students in the program, raising the bar for the students who were not on this trip.

ACCESS IS THE PURPOSE

The \$250,000 campaign exists because a performance selection does not pay for a student's seat on the bus. The campaign exists so that a family's financial situation does not determine whether a student who earned this opportunity gets to take it. That is the work.

OPPORTUNITIES FOR CIVIC LEADERSHIP

- + Formal proclamation at County Commission, City Council, or Board of Education
- + Public statement of support from elected or appointed officials
- + Introductions to businesses and civic organizations
- + Congressional recognition through Rep. Rouzer's office

Civic contact: Brian Millen, PR & Civic Relations | brianpaulmillen@gmail.com | or Mr. Parker, robert.parker@nhcs.net





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07 | BIOS AND CONTACTS

THE PEOPLE AND *program.*

DIRECTOR BIO: FULL

Robert A. Parker is Director of Bands at Eugene Ashley High School in Wilmington, North Carolina, where he has led the program since 2006. Under his direction, the Concert Band and Wind Ensemble earned Superior ratings at the 2026 Concert Music Performance Adjudication, and Ashley was named to the inaugural class of NCBA Programs of Distinction. Parker received the NCBA Eastern District Award of Excellence in February 2026 and will be recognized at the NCMEA conference during the NCBA Board meeting in November 2026. The Ashley Wind Ensemble performed at the 2016 NCMEA Professional Development Conference. He also serves as South MPA Chair for the NCBA Eastern District. As a freshman at Mount Tabor High School, Parker performed at Carnegie Hall with his own band. The 2027 trip brings him back, this time on the podium.

DIRECTOR BIO: SHORT

Robert A. Parker has led Ashley Bands since 2006. He received the NCBA Eastern District Award of Excellence in February 2026 and directs a program whose Concert Band and Wind Ensemble were selected for the March 2027 Carnegie Hall performance, a venue he performed in himself as a student.

PROGRAM BIO

Ashley Bands is the music program of Eugene Ashley High School in Wilmington, North Carolina. Students participate in Concert Band, Wind Ensemble, Jazz Band, Marching Band, and Colorguard. After COVID the program fell to about 52 students; this fall's enrollment is the second highest in twenty years. The program was named an inaugural 2025-2026 NCBA Program of Distinction, and both concert ensembles earned Superior ratings at the 2026 Concert MPA. Ashley High School is located at 555 Halyburton Memorial Pkwy, Wilmington, NC 28412, in New Hanover County Schools.

INTERVIEWS AND REHEARSAL COVERAGE

Student participation and rehearsal visits are coordinated through Mr. Parker and school communication channels. Student and parent interview requests are welcome; please coordinate through Mr. Parker.

KEY CONTACTS

Robert A. Parker

Director of Bands, Ashley High School
South MPA Chair, NCBA Eastern
robert.parker@nhcs.net
(910) 409-4788

Hannah Hales

Booster President
hannah.hales@gmail.com



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FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE

September 2026 | Wilmington, North Carolina

ASHLEY HIGH SCHOOL BANDS EARN INVITATION TO PERFORM AT CARNEGIE HALL

WILMINGTON, NC. The Bands of Ashley High School, the Concert Band and Wind Ensemble of Eugene Ashley High School in Wilmington, North Carolina, have been selected to perform at Carnegie Hall's Stern Auditorium / Perelman Stage on March 25, 2027, as part of the National Band and Orchestra Festival. The two ensembles represent about 100 student musicians and will perform on one of the most recognized stages in the world.

Ashley High School's Concert Band and Wind Ensemble submitted recordings and were selected through the festival's competitive application process. Both bands were selected. Separately, the program was named to the inaugural class of the North Carolina Bandmasters Association (NCBA) Program of Distinction, a statewide recognition in its first year. The two are separate achievements from the same program.

The selection caps a comeback from COVID. Six years ago, Ashley Bands was down to about 52 students, rehearsing outside in masks. Robert A. Parker, Director of Bands and South MPA Chair for the NCBA Eastern District, said then that rebuilding would take seven years. This is the seventh season. In 2026 both concert ensembles earned Superior ratings at Music Performance Adjudication, and this fall's enrollment is the second highest of Parker's twenty years at Ashley. The four-day trip, March 23 through 26, 2027, includes the Carnegie Hall performance and educational experiences in New York City, representing Wilmington and New Hanover County on a national stage.

COMMUNITY CAMPAIGN

A community fundraising campaign with a goal of \$250,000 is underway so that no student has to miss this because of money. Donations are accepted at ashleybands.com/support-carnegie. Gifts are received by Ashley High School Band Boosters, a registered 501(c)(3) nonprofit organization. Contributions are tax-deductible to the extent allowed by law. EIN: 20-5605218.

KEY FACTS

Students performing: About 100
Performance date: March 25, 2027
Venue: Carnegie Hall, Stern Auditorium / Perelman Stage, New York City
Travel dates: March 23-26, 2027
Campaign goal: \$250,000
School: Eugene Ashley High School, Wilmington NC
District: New Hanover County Schools

ABOUT ASHLEY HIGH SCHOOL BANDS

The Bands of Eugene Ashley High School are a New Hanover County Schools program serving students in Concert Band, Wind Ensemble, Jazz Band, and Marching Band. Under the direction of Robert A. Parker, the program has earned consistent Superior ratings at the North Carolina Music Performance Adjudication and was among the inaugural recipients of the NCBA Program of Distinction in 2026. Ashley High School is located in Wilmington, North Carolina.

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MEDIA CONTACT

Robert A. Parker, Director of Bands | robert.parker@nhcs.net | (910) 409-4788

Campaign questions: Hannah Hales, Booster President | hannah.hales@gmail.com. Additional media assets, interviews, and documentation available upon request.